

How to Use Your Per-Diem Meal Deduction Tracker

SKU TAX-007 • PER-DIEM MEAL TRACKER

IRS Pub 463-compliant meal tracker. Captures the 5 elements of a deductible meal (date, amount, business purpose, attendees, location), routes between **standard meal allowance (per-diem)** and **actual cost** methods, and applies the correct deduction percentage.

The percentages (IRC §274)

- **50%** — standard business meals
- **100%** — meals provided to employees (cleaning crew pizza, contractor lunch as compensation)
- **0%** — entertainment (golf, concerts) post-2017 TCJA
- **80%** — DOT hours-of-service workers (rare for STR)

First-time setup (3 min)

1. Open tab **Settings**:

- B5 → active tax year (2026)
- Per-diem M&IE rates by city (defaults: \$80 high-cost / \$59 low-cost). Update from gsa.gov/travel/plan-book/per-diem-rates if needed.
- Schedule classification (E or C).

Every meal you take on the road

Open tab **Meals Log**. Fill a row:

- Date · Property/Trip · Location · Restaurant · Attendees · Business purpose · Amount · Tip · Receipt kept Y/N · Method (Actual/Per-diem) · Deductible % (50/80/100/0)

The 5-element rule: if Attendees, Business purpose, or Receipt is missing on a meal $\geq$ \$75, the IRS doesn't recognize it. The tab flags incomplete rows.

When traveling overnight

Open tab **Per-Diem Log** instead. Fill:

- Date · Travel destination · # full days away · # partial days · M&IE rate

Workbook computes daily \$. **Travel must be away from tax home overnight** OR more than 12 hours to qualify.

Reading the outputs

- **YTD deductible — Actual + YTD deductible — Per-diem** = your total meal deduction
- **Per-month chart** — meal \$ by month
- **Donut chart** — deduction by purpose

The workbook flags if you accidentally double-counted (same date appears in both Actual + Per-diem).

At tax time

Sum the YTD deductible amount → enter on Schedule E or Schedule C as Line 24b (Travel) or Line 24c (Meals 50%). Your CPA will route correctly from the Meals Log tab.

Questions?

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Get on our list at thestrledger.com/47 for our free "47 Airbnb Tax Deductions Most Hosts Miss" guide.
